Beyond the Bookshelf: A Vision for the Future of Learning

Monica Malhotra Kandhari has turned a publishing legacy into a living ecosystem of learning, and she is only getting started.



Monica Malhotra Kandhari, Managing Director, MBD Group

There is a particular kind of leader who refuses to let legacy become a limitation. Monica Malhotra Kandhari, Managing Director of MBD Group and the driving force behind AASOKA, is that kind of leader. Under her leadership, MBD Group continues to build on its rich legacy in educational publishing while expanding its presence across printing, publishing, edtech, real estate and hospitality, evolving into a diversified conglomerate that reflects India's changing needs and aspirations.

MBD Group's publishing roots run deep. With a catalogue of more than 8,000 titles, the Group continues to refresh approximately 800–1000 titles each year to address evolving curricula and educational requirements. Its international presence includes a publishing office in South Africa, inclusion in the country's National Catalogue and operations across more than seven countries. For Monica Malhotra Kandhari, however, content was always the foundation, never the ceiling.

That vision finds expression in AASOKA, a blended learning platform for K–12 education. Bringing together digital content, video lessons, e-books and assessments, the platform supports schools, teachers, students and parents across different stages of learning. "Education is not a product, it is a continuous relationship between a learner and the world," she says, a philosophy reflected in AASOKA's approach to learning. Today, the platform reaches more than 5,500 schools across 500 cities in 24 states, benefiting over 10 lakh students and supporting the annual training of one lakh teachers.

The platform's growing reach has also brought significant recognition. AASOKA was ranked 1 in TIME and Statista's World's Top EdTech Rising Stars of 2025, while also earning a place among Forbes India's Most Innovative Companies 2026. These acknowledgements highlight AASOKA's growing footprint in digital learning and its efforts to make tech-enabled learning more accessible to schools across India.

AASOKA Wizkids brings this approach to preschool education through a franchise model that combines books, technology and hands-on activities. As children progress, the FLN Lab develops foundational literacy and numeracy through play-based learning, while the AI STEAM Lab extends practical learning to robotics, artificial intelligence and emerging technologies for students in Grades 1–12.

This commitment to experiential learning also extends beyond the classroom. Through its CSR initiative, Robotics Lab on Wheels, MBD Group takes robotics and STEAM learning to children in budget schools, helping them explore technology through practical, hands-on experiences.

As MBD Group continues to diversify, hospitality and real estate have become important parts of its business. Monica Malhotra Kandhari leads the design and construction of the Group's hospitality projects, while her sister, Sonica Malhotra Kandhari, Joint Managing Director of MBD Group, oversees its hospitality and realty portfolio. Their work spans the Radisson Blu MBD Hotel, Noida, and retail and lifestyle developments such as MBD Neopolis Mall in Jalandhar.

The Group's master franchise partnership with Radisson Hotel Group further signals its ambitions in hospitality, with plans to add 40 Radisson RED and 10 Radisson Collection properties to its portfolio across India. Together, these ventures reflect a business that continues to explore new opportunities while drawing on the experience and foundations built over seven decades.

Beyond her work within the Group, Monica Malhotra contributes to the wider industry through several leadership and advisory roles, both nationally and internationally. She chairs the FICCI Publishing Committee, serves on the CII Northern Regional Council and the Executive Committee of the Federation of Indian Publishers (FIP). She is also a member of the International Publishers Association (IPA) and the Senate of Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar. Her leadership and contributions to the industry have earned her several distinctions. She has been recognised by Forbes India as an Iconic Woman Leader, ranked 2nd in PrintWeek's Power 100 and named an ET Change Maker.

Monica Malhotra Kandhari is a business leader who understands that the most powerful thing you can build is not a building, but a generation.